

MARTY GRAS

THE ARCHITECT OF VIBE

A CRASH COURSE IN THE ATTENTION ECONOMY

The TikTok *Field Manual*

*Everything the TikTok Creator Academy teaches – distilled, structured
and translated into a propulsion plan for a personal media company.*

SOURCE

tiktok.com/creator-academy

METHOD

Nine Opus agents

EDITION

May 2026

PREPARED BY

Alfred

This is not a summary of opinions about TikTok. It is a structured reading of one source – the official TikTok Creator Academy – and nothing else. Every framework, threshold and quotation in these pages traces back to **tiktok.com/creator-academy**. Where the platform does not state something plainly, the manual says so rather than fill the gap with folklore.

The build

The Creator Academy library was divided into nine territories. Nine Opus-class research agents were dispatched in parallel, each owning one territory and restricted to the Creator Academy alone. Their reports were reconciled into the single document you are holding. The Academy renders as a JavaScript application, so the substance was recovered through the search index rather than raw page fetches – the content is the platform's own, surfaced rather than scraped.

Reading conventions

- Direct platform language is set in *italic quotation*. Numbers are TikTok's own.
- A **UNVERIFIED** tag marks anything the Academy did not state outright. Treat it as a flag, not a fact.
- The closing section – **Part XII** – is the translation: the Academy doctrine turned into a Marty Gras growth plan.

THE LIBRARY, MAPPED

Eight video-course tracks plus a parallel article system. View counts are the Academy's own.

Use These Features To Grow	12M
Grow With Subscription	17M
Increase Your Engagement	5.1M
Create Better Videos	1M
How To Monetize On TikTok	2.9M
Learn From Other Creators	2.9M
Follow Community Guidelines	348K
Creator Rewards Program	261K

One honest caveat. TikTok rotates these tracks and counts. The figures above are accurate to the rendered index at time of research – directionally true, not frame-stable.

The platform tells you, in its own words, exactly how it works. Almost nobody reads it. That is the entire opportunity.

I	The TikTok Thesis	Why the platform is a culture, not a channel
II	Foundations	Account, profile, TikTok Studio, the search engine inside the app
III	The Algorithm & Discovery	The recommendation system, in TikTok's own words
IV	Content Craft	The hook, the structure, the quality premium
V	Engagement & Community	Turning a scroller into a member
VI	The Growth Feature Stack	Every native surface and what it unlocks
VII	Monetisation	The Creator Rewards formula, decoded
VIII	Subscription & Recurring Revenue	The owned economy above the rented one
IX	Commerce & Brand Partnerships	Native trust as the currency
X	Integrity, Eligibility & Well-being	Why clean play is the growth strategy
XI	Lessons From Other Creators	The four principles every success story repeats
XII	The Marty Gras Propulsion Playbook	The translation – doctrine into a concrete plan
A-B-C	Appendices — The Numbers Card • Glossary • Source Ledger	

Parts I through XI are platform-universal. Part XII is yours.

Part I

The TikTok Thesis

Before a single tactic, the worldview. TikTok is not a distribution channel you push to – it is a culture you earn into, every single time you post. The Creator Academy states this outright. Most creators never internalise it.

-
- › The 96% truth
 - › The attention toll
 - › Jab, jab, jab, right hook
 - › Every post re-auditions
 - › Native over repurposed
 - › Document, do not create



The Creator Academy opens on a number that reframes everything that follows: users spend **96% of their time on TikTok scrolling the For You feed**. Not browsing profiles. Not searching followings. The feed. This single fact dismantles the inherited mental model of social media – that you build an audience and then broadcast to it.

On TikTok there is no warm audience to coast on. The Academy is explicit: distribution is decided per video by a prediction system, not by your follower count. Reach is not banked. It is earned cold, every time, by the content itself. A no-name video can outrun a large account – and yesterday's viral hit guarantees nothing tomorrow.

This is the platform's structural promise and its structural threat in one sentence. The Academy does not bury it. It leads with it. The serious creator builds their entire operating posture on it.

The Vaynerchuk lens

Gary Vaynerchuk's framing maps onto TikTok almost too cleanly. **Jab, jab, jab, right hook** – give, give, give native value, then make the ask.

Document, do not create – the sustainable engine is a documented point of view, not a production studio. **Native over repurposed** – content built for the surface beats content poured onto it. The Academy does not cite him. It does not need to. It teaches the same doctrine as platform mechanics, with numbers attached.

THE MECHANIC, DRAWN

1

You post.

No credit carried from past performance. The video enters the prediction pipeline on its own merits.

2

The first seconds are the toll booth.

Watch time and retention are the strong signals. If the open does not hold, distribution never widens.

3

Interest compounds – or it stops.

Sustained watching, replays and shares expand reach. Indifference ends it. The content is the only lever.

4

The next post starts again at zero.

There is no audience moat. This is why volume of native, authentic reps beats sporadic polish.

96%

of user time on TikTok is spent in the For You feed – the Academy's own figure. The feed, not the follow, is the platform.

THE REFRAME

Old model: build an audience, then broadcast to it.

TikTok model: every post re-auditions for distribution from cold. The audience is the consequence of the content, never the precondition for its reach.

Followers are not the distribution mechanism. The feed is. Internalise that and every other chapter becomes obvious.

Part II

Foundations

The work before the work. Account architecture, a profile built as a search-indexed pitch, and TikTok Studio as the cockpit. Get this wrong and everything downstream leaks.

-
- › Personal versus Business
 - › TikTok Studio cockpit
 - › Creator Search Insights
 - › The profile as a pitch
 - › Analytics as a calendar
 - › The Content Gap engine



TikTok has collapsed the old toggle. There is no separate “Creator account” to switch on – every Personal Account ships with creator tools, analytics and monetisation eligibility by default. The only account-type decision is **Personal versus Business**, and the Academy frames it as close to a one-way door.

PERSONAL ACCOUNT

- Advanced creator tools and full analytics
- **Creator Rewards Program eligible** – the flagship payout path
- The Unlimited Sound Library – 80,000+ tracks
- The default for a creator, artist or public figure

BUSINESS ACCOUNT

- Link-in-bio and app-download link
- Auto-Message DM suite, business category
- Commercial Music Library in place of Unlimited
- **Not** eligible for Creator Rewards

The Academy's explicit warning. Do not switch back and forth. To run a brand and a personal creator presence, run two separate accounts – switching to Business and back forfeits Creator Rewards eligibility and trips a thirty-day waiting period before re-applying.

The profile is a search-indexed pitch

The Academy treats the profile as owned media that the feed funnels into. The handle convention it teaches is search-engine optimisation for a social profile: *Name / What You Do* – the example given is *Lily / Creator Growth Coach*. The bio is a 160-character pitch to a specific audience, not a vibe. The anti-pattern it names by name is the vague bio – “*I post cool stuff.*”

- **Handle** carries keywords – changeable once every 30 days
- **Bio** – 160 characters, a clear value statement
- **Photo** – identical across every platform for recognition
- **Links** – Edit profile, add the funnel destinations
- **Pinned** – up to three videos, a permanent trailer

BIO · DO NOT / DO

~~I post cool stuff~~

Lily | Creator Growth Coach

Weekly systems to turn a niche into a living. New here? Start with the pinned three.

160-character ceiling. Every character is the highest-leverage owned real estate on the platform.

TikTok Studio & The Search Engine Inside The App

TikTok Studio is the operational cockpit – in-app, standalone and on the web. The Academy is direct that management-heavy work belongs on the web version: scheduling, content management and analytics.

The surface

- Create and edit – clips, sound, text, vertical or landscape
- Schedule – up to 30 days ahead on web; bulk upload up to 30 videos at 1,000+ followers
- Analytics – Overview, Content, Followers, LIVE
- Comments, playlists, inspiration, and the Creator Academy itself, in-Studio

Analytics is a programming calendar

The most actionable instruction in the foundations curriculum: the **Followers** tab tells you when your community is active, and the Academy says outright to use that as “*your programming calendar guide, aka when to post.*” Per-video, the **retention rate** pinpoints the exact second viewers dropped. Demographics are predictive models, not confirmed data – the Academy says so itself.

THE COCKPIT, MAPPED



Create

Edit clips, sound, images, text



Schedule

30 days ahead · 30-video bulk



Analyse

Overview · Content · Followers · LIVE



Learn

Creator Academy, in-Studio

THE SINGLE MOST STRATEGIC FOUNDATIONS TOOL · CREATOR SEARCH INSIGHTS → CONTENT GAP

01

Open Search Insights

Search bar → “Creator Search Insights” → View.
Also in TikTok Studio.



02

Content Gap tab

Topics with high search demand and little quality supply.



03

Make the answer

AI-suggested ideas and must-use keywords per topic.



04

The payoff

Higher watch time, retention, search rank and views.

High demand, low supply. The Content Gap tab is a content-commissioning radar – arguably the most valuable single instrument the Academy hands a curator.

Part III

The Algorithm & Discovery

The recommendation system, decoded from the platform's own documentation.
Three signal families, a prediction score, a variety referee, and a second feed called
Search that compounds while the first one decays.

-
- › Three signal families
 - › The 90-day window
 - › Search as the second feed
 - › The prediction pipeline
 - › Eligibility versus removal
 - › The cadence myth, busted



How Distribution Is Actually Decided

The Academy describes the recommendation system in plain terms. It weighs three families of signal, scores every video for every user, ranks, then runs a variety check before it serves. The weighting rule is the load-bearing sentence in the entire territory.

SIGNAL WEIGHTING – THE RANKING RULE

User Interactions watch time, finishes, likes, shares, comments

Strongest – a finished long video is the strong signal

Content Information sounds, hashtags, views, country published

Moderate

User Information device, language, location, time zone

Weak – same country is a weak indicator

The exact words. “Strong indicators of interest, like finishing a longer video, receive greater weight than weak indicators, like being in the same country.”

THE PREDICTION PIPELINE

1

Read recent behaviour

Watched, finished, liked, skipped, saved

2

Build a prediction score

Probability of like, share, comment, skip – combined

3

Rank high to low

Closest match to predicted preference first

4

Variety check

No two in a row with the same sound or creator

5

Regional layer

Ensures some in-region creators appear

90

days – the window the For You feed generally pulls recommendations from. Trend-driven reach decays inside a quarter.

PERFORMANCE EXTENDS OVER DAYS

The Academy explicitly corrects the “dead in an hour” myth: a video peaks soon after publishing but performance “*extends over a couple of days*”. Sustained interest sustains recommendation.

THE VARIETY REFEREE

The system intersperses diverse content to break the filter bubble. Category-spanning work is structurally favoured – a genuine tailwind for a curator.

Permitted on TikTok does not mean eligible for the For You feed. The Academy draws a hard line: some content is removed, some is age-restricted, and a large category is simply **not recommended** – it survives, but the feed will not carry it.

NOT ELIGIBLE FOR THE FOR YOU FEED

- Unoriginal content – copied, or minimal original input
- Low quality – split screens, meaningless reactions, slideshows
- Advertising with personal or business contact details
- Clickbait with no meaningful value
- Content from creators under 16 – not recommended to strangers

The operative risk is silent throttling, not the ban. Removal is rare. For a serious creator the realistic threat is For-You ineligibility – the post lives, the reach does not. The Performance tab shows a warning bar when it happens.

SEARCH OPTIMISATION – SAY IT CLEARLY, DO NOT STUFF

Description, voiceover, captions and on-screen text make the video legible to Search. **The cap is five hashtags.** Keyword and hashtag stuffing is explicitly spam-flaggable and counter-productive. Two myths the Academy debunks by name: hidden swiped-off keyword text, and long hashtag lists. Neither works.

TREND-DRIVEN	EVERGREEN & SEARCH
Lives in the For You feed	Lives in Search, indefinitely
~90-day decay window	Compounds with no decay
Fast spike, fast fade	Slow build, keeps working
Reach only	Reach <i>and</i> monetised – search value pays

*Search is the second feed – and the only one that compounds.
“Evergreen gems that keep working long after you hit post.”*

THE CADENCE MYTH, IN TIKTOK’S OWN WORDS

“The number of videos you post each day does not impact your content’s performance.” Consistency builds an expectation the audience enjoys – it is not a ranking lever. The “post five times a day” folklore is third-party, and the Academy contradicts it directly. Optimise clarity, not volume.

Part IV

Content Craft

The making of the video itself. A skills ladder from hook to structure to finish, every rung backed by the platform's own performance data – a 1.1-million-video study and a 72% quality premium.

-
- › The 3-5 second hook
 - › The pacing toolkit
 - › The quality premium
 - › Freytag, remixed
 - › Length is rewarded
 - › Sound works twice



The Hook, The Structure, The Pace

PART IV · CRAFT

The Academy's craft core is a single native thesis: hook in the first **3–5 seconds**, structure like a story, pace so attention never leaks. The hook is not a tip – it is the entry toll on an infinite feed.

"The first 3–5 seconds of your video is SO important. DON'T waste it on a PAUSE." Lead with the strongest shot, or the result itself, before the reveal.

Freytag, remixed for the feed

The Academy teaches a 19th-century five-stage model by name – exposition, rising action, climax, falling action, resolution – then immediately tells you to break its chronology: *"start at the end or in the middle of the climax, and then backtrack."* The payoff is teased in the first frame because linear storytelling loses the scroll.

THE PACING TOOLKIT – KEEP THE ENERGY UP AFTER THE HOOK

1 · Captions so the audience can follow without sound.

2 · Change outfit, location, angle or shot to reset attention.

3 · Effects & sticker text to introduce ideas and break rhythm.

4 · Voiceover – clear, high quality, matched to tone.

5 · Trending sound for discoverability and shareability.

The instinct – open on the climax, backfill the setup.

HOOK ANATOMY · SECONDS 0–5

0–1s · strongest visual lands

1–3s · the promise / the result

3–5s · the reason to stay

Red zone: any static pause here forfeits the video

A good TikTok grabs you from the start, pulls you through the turns, and holds you to the end. The structure is ancient. The edit is native.

The Academy does not argue craft as taste. It argues it as measured performance, and publishes the numbers. Two are decisive: a study of 1.1 million videos on length, and a quality premium that should end the volume-over-craft debate.

+43%

reach for videos over 60 seconds

≈3×

watch time over 60 seconds versus shorter

+64%

watch time for videos past two minutes

+72%

watch time per view for high-quality creators

The quality premium

"High-quality creators outperform other creators by 72% in accumulated watch time per video view. Even compared with other creators with 10,000+ followers, high-quality accounts maintain a significant 42% lead." Quality is defined as polished production, attention to detail and clear storytelling. Split screens, meaningless reactions and slideshows are not just weak – they are For-You-ineligible.

Sound works twice

Eighty-eight percent of users say sound is vital to the experience. Yet over 30% watch on mute. The craft demand is therefore dual-layer: trending audio for the algorithm and the feel, on-screen text and captions for the muted majority. Every video must work with the sound off and on.

THE SKILLS LADDER

04

Edit & finish

In-app tools, covers, captions

03

Audio 101 → 102

Mic six inches out; a closet is a studio

02

Lighting 101

Three-point – key, fill, back

01

Filming 101 → 102

Direct, then compose – angles, movement, the 9:16 frame

Smart Split. TikTok Studio Web auto-clips, reframes, captions and transcribes long content into multiple shorts. Eligibility: 1,000+ followers, up to 150 minutes of source per month. This is the literal long-form-to-shorts pipeline, built into the platform.

Part V

Engagement & Community

The conversion that matters most – a scroller into a member. The Academy spends its tactical capital on the jabs and treats the follow as the earned right hook. It usually takes more than one good video.

-
- › The engagement loop
 - › The community ladder
 - › The "more than once" law
 - › Duet and Stitch
 - › Cadence as ritual
 - › The Ask table



The Academy's thesis, repeated almost verbatim across articles: *"Creating a strong community on TikTok starts with engagement, and viewers who feel appreciated and rewarded for returning are more likely to become loyal followers."*

The closed loop it teaches: post native content, draw comments, reply with text, a like or a video, mine those comments for the next video, repeat. Replying is framed as both a community act and a distribution signal – it *"signals activity to the algorithm"* and boosts reach.

THE LAW OF MORE THAN ONCE

"It usually takes more than one good video to get people to follow you. Most viewers need to see you deliver more than once." This is the platform's own permission to optimise for a returning audience over viral spikes.



The engagement loop - the comment-mine feeds the next post

THE COMMUNITY LADDER - EACH RUNG EARN THE NEXT

1	Scroller Cold feed impression – everything starts here
2	Commenter Pulled into the discourse, replied to personally
3	Repeat viewer Has seen you deliver "more than once"
4	Loyal follower Won over by repeated, recognisable value
5	Subscriber The Subscription community – the explicit top rung the Academy points to

The Academy mandates no posting number. It mandates a **ritual**. The worked examples it gives are appointment content: “*take viewers into your kitchen every Sunday*”; “*teach a new drill every Tuesday*.”

The operating routine it prescribes is, in effect, document-do-not-create: keep an idea notes page, dedicate one or two days to batch filming, and set aside one posting day built entirely from audience comments. The loop feeds itself.

Duet & Stitch. Stitch clips up to 5 seconds of another video into yours. Up to five accounts can collaborate on one post – it appears on every collaborator’s profile, a reach multiplier across communities. Permissions live in Privacy and Safety.

CADENCE AS RITUAL



No mandated frequency. Consistency over volume – the ritual is the contract with the audience.

THE ASK TABLE – EVERY ACT IS TWO SIGNALS AT ONCE

ACTION	WHAT IT SIGNALS TO THE COMMUNITY	WHAT IT SIGNALS TO THE ALGORITHM
Reply to a comment	You are seen and heard	Account activity, reach lift
Reply with a video	Intimacy at scale – personally answered	New native asset from a real prompt
Ask “what do you want?”	Co-authorship of the channel	Comment volume, discourse depth
Duet / Stitch a reply	The audience becomes the content	Cross-community distribution
Comment on peers in-niche	Belonging in the culture	Audience cross-pollination

Jab, jab, jab – reply, recognise, ask. The follow is the right hook, and it only lands once the jabs have built the reciprocity.

Part VI

The Growth Feature Stack

The product surface is not a toolbox – it is a retention engine and a progression ladder. Every native feature exists to extend time-on-content and to unlock at a follower threshold.

-
- › The feature matrix
 - › Which feature, which goal
 - › Series – paid long-form
 - › Eligibility thresholds
 - › LIVE setup & the 60-80 rule
 - › The LIVE economy



FEATURE	WHAT IT IS	UNLOCK	THE STATED GROWTH PLAY
TikTok LIVE	Real-time broadcast, no time limit	18+	Real-time community; longer is rewarded
Stories	24-hour ephemeral posts	Open	Stay present between regular posts
Photo Mode	Swipeable carousel, up to 35 images	Open	Swipe time is an engagement signal
Series	Paid collection, up to 80 videos, 30s-20m each	10k followers*	Paywalled long-form
Playlists	Themed binge sets, no total cap	10k followers	Chain viewers into a back-catalogue
Q&A	Designated question surface	Creator tools	Answer at scale, build an archive
Add Yours	Participation sticker prompt	Open	Built-in notification and discovery loop
Captions	Editable auto-subtitles	Open	Global reach, the muted majority
Scheduling	Web, 30 days ahead, 30-video bulk	1k followers	Sustainable cadence without manual posting

*Series has a sub-10k bypass: apply with a link to premium content previously sold elsewhere, via TikTok Studio.

THE THRESHOLD LADDER

18+ **TikTok LIVE**
Real-time, no time cap

1k **Bulk scheduling · Smart Split**
Operational scale

10k **Series · Playlists**
Paid long-form and binge sets

150k **Pre-post review**
Check a video for violations before posting

The product surface itself is gamified growth.

LIVE SETUP & THE 60-80 RULE

Title ≤ 32 chars
Prevent auto-end; optional stream key + RTMP for multistream

Up to 20 moderators
Keyword comment filter, effects, multi-guest

Target 60-80 minutes
Beats 10-20 min – a LIVE room only exists while you are in it

The LIVE economy. Gifts convert to Diamonds; Diamonds drive the Weekly Ranking. The top 20 creators earn prizes; ranks four to ten get an Explore-More feature. LIVE Subscription layers recurring multi-month revenue on top. **UNVERIFIED** – a 1,000-follower LIVE gate is widely cited but the Academy text surfaced only an age requirement.

Part VII

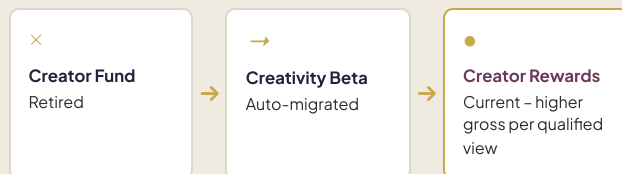
Monetisation

The most quantitative territory in the manual. The Creator Rewards Program is the flagship – a four-metric formula on original, over-one-minute, search-valuable video. Get the numbers right.

-
- › Programme lineage
 - › The four-metric formula
 - › RPM mechanics
 - › The eligibility gate
 - › Qualified views
 - › The programme comparison



PROGRAMME LINEAGE



THE ELIGIBILITY GATE – ALL REQUIRED

- **18+** (19 in South Korea)
- **10,000+ followers**
- **100,000+ video views** in the last 30 days
- **Personal Account**, public, in good standing
- Registered in one of **8 countries** – US, UK, Germany, Japan, South Korea, France, Mexico, Brazil

Qualifying video. Original, **over one minute**, at least **1,000 qualified For You views** before it earns. Not a Duet, Stitch, Photo Mode or ad. Apply in TikTok Studio – reply within three days.

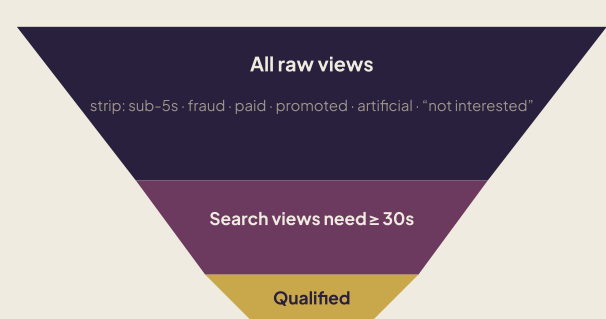
THE FOUR-METRIC FORMULA

- **Originality**
A point of view unique to the creator
- **Play duration**
Watch time and finish rate together
- **Search value**
Alignment with in-demand search terms
- **Audience engagement**
Likes, comments, shares

\$50

Worked example, the Academy's own: 10,000 qualified views at a \$5 RPM ≈ \$50. Redeemed on the 15th at a \$50 USD floor.

THE QUALIFIED-VIEW FILTER



A For You view counts only at 5+ seconds watched. One account is one unique view. 1,000 qualified views starts the earning.

RPM – TWO COMPONENTS

B

Standard Reward

The base – region and language of the audience

×

Additional Reward

The quality multiplier – watch time, retention at 30/40/50/60/90s, completion, search value

=

RPM

Gross revenue per 1,000 qualified views

Originality is enforced economics. Duets, Stitches and watermarked re-uploads are not just discouraged – they are structurally unpaid. The fix: appear on screen, add voiceover opinion, reconstruct with new editing.

PROGRAMME	MIN FOLLOWERS	AGE	BASIS	REVENUE SHARE
Creator Rewards	10,000	18	RPM on qualified views	Dynamic RPM
Video Gifts	10,000	18	Diamonds on videos	Per virtual item
LIVE Gifts	—	18	Diamonds on LIVE	50% of net virtual-item revenue
Scaled LIVE Rewards	Select	18	Missions × popularity	Up to 53%
Subscription	10,000	18	Recurring monthly	70% → up to 90%

TikTok pays a quality multiplier for content that earns attention rather than demands it. The right hook is an original, over-one-minute, searchable video.

Part VIII

Subscription & Recurring Revenue

The owned economy above the rented one. A one-off view is a transaction with the feed. A subscriber is a standing relationship with the creator. The Academy draws that line itself.

-
- › The eligibility gate
 - › The benefit stack
 - › The 70 → 90 waterfall
 - › Tiers and pricing
 - › Subscription vs Super Fan
 - › Recurring versus one-off



Subscription is the Academy’s recurring-revenue pillar – a monthly paid membership where the most engaged followers pay to enter an exclusive community. It is framed explicitly as *“predictable recurring monthly revenue versus single-transaction earnings.”*

THE ELIGIBILITY GATE

- **18+**, account in good standing
- **10,000+ followers** and **100,000+ views** in the past month
- Or meet the LIVE path – 18+, 1,000 followers, for the legacy LIVE route

Tiers and pricing

Default **\$5.99/month**. Creator-selectable **\$2.99 to \$99.99**, up to three tiers. Users pay in local currency. Super Fan – the LIVE upgrade – is **\$9.99/month** and instantly lifts a fan to Fan Club level 10.

THE BENEFIT STACK

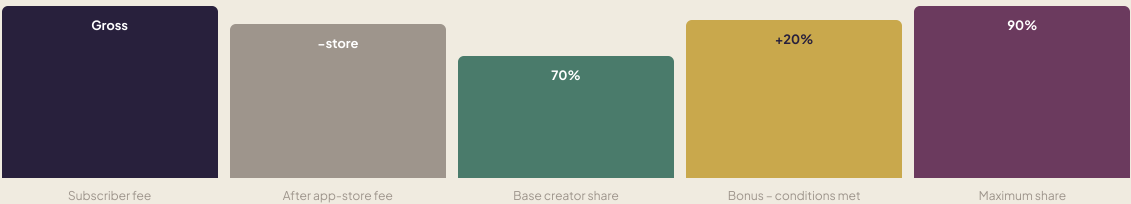
Subscription · video

- Subscriber-only videos, LIVEs and notes
- Tenure-tiered subscriber badge
- Up to 35 custom emotes in DMs and group chats
- Customisable perks – topic votes, follow-backs, collabs

Super Fan · LIVE

- Exclusive LIVEs and comment sections
- Upgraded badge, entrance effects, dazzling gifts
- A Super-Fan-only space

THE REVENUE-SHARE WATERFALL



The +20% bonus: 10k+ followers, 100k+ monthly views, guideline-compliant, and a first subscriber-only video posted in the current month.

Reach is rented from the algorithm every day. A subscriber base is owned monthly. That is the entire strategic difference.

Part IX

Commerce & Partnerships

On TikTok the creator's voice drives the purchase, not the brand's. And disclosure does not tax reach – opacity does. A two-million-video study settles the argument the platform's own creators keep having.

-
- › The trust statistics
 - › The disclosure flow
 - › Ways to earn from brands
 - › The disclosure myth-buster
 - › TikTok One
 - › The one-page media kit



65%

rely on creator recommendations and reviews when deciding what to buy

58%

trust brands more after learning about them from TikTok creators

~2M

videos studied – zero performance difference for proper disclosure

The single most strategically important finding in this territory inverts the conventional creator fear. The penalty is not for being sponsored. It is for hiding it.

"If you do not display the proper disclosure, your content may not be eligible for the For You feed." Conversely, labelling a post as a Paid partnership *"will not affect the way TikTok recommends content."* Disclose cleanly, keep full distribution, monetise without eroding trust.

Branded Content Policy. Prohibited industries cannot be promoted – alcohol, tobacco and nicotine, adult products, and paid political content. Disclosure is organic posts only.

THE DISCLOSURE FLOW

1

Create a post

Content disclosure and ads

2

Disclose commercial content · on

Choose own brand, or third-party

3

Label resolves

"Promotional content" or "Paid partnership"

✓

For You eligibility preserved

No reach penalty

TIKTOK ONE – THE CREATOR MARKETPLACE SUCCESSOR

The legacy TTCM no longer posts new campaigns. Brand partnerships now live in TikTok One – open applications, flat-fee or revenue-share, deliverables on the brand account, your account, or as an in-feed ad. Content Suite auto-surfaces eligible brand-mentioning videos to advertisers with no submission.

THE ONE-PAGE MEDIA KIT

The Academy spec, exactly: a one-page snapshot – best stats per platform, audience demographics, deliverables with rates, top recent collaborations. *"Your media kit should sell you before you even say a word."*

Part X

Integrity, Eligibility & Well-being

One continuous argument – integrity is upstream of reach, and reach is upstream of money. The same words that define compliance define what the algorithm and the payout formula reward.

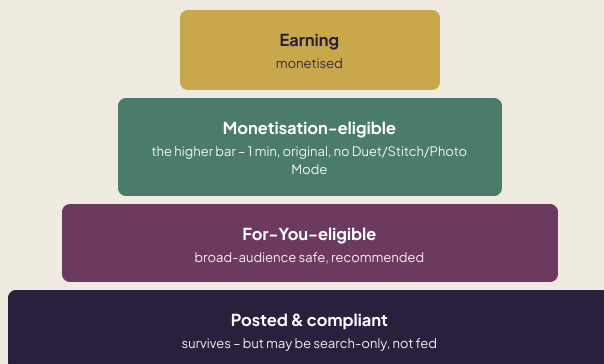
-
- › The eligibility pyramid
 - › The Originality Policy
 - › Sustainable creation
 - › Strike mechanics
 - › Music as a minefield
 - › Integrity as strategy



Clean Play Is The Growth Strategy

PART X · INTEGRITY

The Academy teaches one triage and four ascending gates. Originality runs up the spine of all of them – it is a scored input to both the recommender and the payout formula, not compliance theatre.



Two demotion exits: removed for a guideline violation, or For-You-ineligible but still searchable.

STRIKE & ENFORCEMENT



Violation → remove + strike

Bucketed by feature or by policy, not one counter



Threshold in a bucket

Permanent ban for that feature or policy



Strikes expire at 90 days

Account Check – status in one click



Appeal

Restores content, removes the penalty

Music is a minefield. Default to the Commercial Music Library. Any non-cleared track triggers Music Usage Confirmation – fail it and *the music is muted*. A media brand needs a CML-first audio standard operating procedure.

Reposting without a fresh spin is not just risky. It is unmonetisable by formula. The platform pays for the unique perspective and demonetises the borrowed one.

Part XI

Lessons From Other Creators

The most-watched track in the territory is a case-study series. Strip the names away and the principles converge on four ideas – and they are the same words the guidelines use.

-
- › Authenticity
 - › Consistency over perfection
 - › The convergence
 - › Niche focus
 - › Community as engagement
 - › Distribution physics



The Four Principles Every Story Repeats

PART XI · LESSONS

The Creator Spotlight series rhymes with the Community Guidelines. The same vocabulary – authentic, original, high-quality – defines both what compliant content is and what successful content credits for its growth. This is not coincidence. It is the platform telling you the rules and the strategy are the same document.

● Authenticity

"Success on TikTok is all about authenticity – find the niche or topic that speaks to you, not just what you think people want to see." The unique stories and talents that make you specific.

● Niche focus

"The more you focus, the more likely you are to find a community of enthusiastic and passionate fans." Narrow taste compounds into recognisable brand equity.

● Consistency over perfection

"Maintaining a steady stream of high-quality content is always better than rushing." Iterate on the highest-performing videos and audience feedback.

● Community as engagement

Reply with video, comment across the niche, continue conversations across posts. Quality builds trust. The endgame is the Subscription community.

THE CONVERGENCE – DISTRIBUTION PHYSICS, IN TIKTOK'S OWN FRAMING

Authenticity, niche, consistency and active community are not success tropes. They are scored inputs to the recommender and the rewards formula. Volume plus iteration on data beats polished, sporadic drops – the platform's own correction of creator folklore. The serious operator stops treating the rules and the growth plan as two different things.

Play clean is not the safe option. On this platform it is, mechanically, the growth option.

Part XII

The Marty Gras Propulsion Playbook

Eleven parts of platform doctrine, now translated into one venture's plan. Not what TikTok teaches – what Marty Gras does with it. The Architect of Vibe, building on the platform that decides reach by the content alone.

-
- › The positioning call
 - › The curation engine
 - › The phase gates
 - › The funnel
 - › Pillars into formats
 - › The 90-day cadence

The Positioning Call & The Funnel

Marty Gras is a Cultural Facilitator – a personal media company built on perspective, not posts. The Academy's doctrine is unusually kind to exactly this model. Four platform mechanics align with the brand rather than fight it.

- **Originality is the moat.** A point-of-view brand clears every originality test the platform polices, while the aggregator competitors it is differentiating against are unpaid by formula.
- **Search value rewards the essay instinct.** Evergreen, query-shaped cultural pieces compound and pay – the opposite of trend-chasing decay.
- **The variety referee favours a curator.** Category-spanning work is structurally injected, not penalised.
- **Long-form is rewarded.** Over-60-second, over-two-minute video earns more reach and watch time. Depth is native here.

THE POSITIONING CALL

Stay Personal. Never Business. Business forfeits Creator Rewards entirely and trips the one-way-door warning. For a Cultural Facilitator this is a clean, high-confidence decision.

Handle & bio as positioning. The *Name / What You Do* convention is search-indexed identity. The 160-character bio is the highest-leverage owned real estate to route to Epiphany and the podcast.

THE PROPULSION FUNNEL – FREE REACH FEEDS TWO OWNED DESTINATIONS



Free TikTok reach is the jab. Subscription and the Epiphany tier are the right hooks. The Academy gates them at 10k followers and 100k monthly views – that is the milestone to engineer toward.

For a brand built on cultural curation, **Creator Search Insights → Content Gap** is the editorial calendar. High demand, low quality supply is the curation thesis, quantified by the platform itself.

The podcast pipeline

Smart Split is purpose-built for a media company – AI auto-clips, reframes and captions the podcast and long-form into native shorts at 1,000+ followers, 150 source-minutes a month. The Freytag-remix is the cut: lead with the payoff line from the episode, backfill the setup.

The dual-layer mandate

Eighty-eight percent value sound; over 30% watch muted. Every cultural argument must live on screen in text – the take cannot be audio-only. This is non-negotiable for a commentary brand.

SERIES AS THE PAYWALLED SALON

Up to 80 videos, 30s-20m each – the native home for premium cultural long-form. The sub-10k bypass matters: with premium content already sold off-platform – a paid Epiphany tier – Marty Gras can apply before 10k. A fast on-ramp.

PILLARS INTO NATIVE FORMATS

MIND

Search-gap explainers – the essay instinct, monetised

SYSTEM

Series – paywalled long-form frameworks

SOUL

LIVE – the cultural salon, real-time

BODY

Stories – the off-the-cuff connective layer

CULTURE

Reaction-critique – the native curation format

Reaction-critique is TikTok's own spec for cultural commentary: insightful commentary as the majority of the video, your expertise informing the opinion, pause the clip, comment at start, middle and end.

SUBSCRIPTION AS THE EPIPHANY ANALOGUE

TikTok Subscription is the on-platform mirror of the paid newsletter tier – recurring, owned, 70 to 90% share. Behind the paywall is document-do-not-create: the curation reasoning, early drops, the cutting-room floor. No new production burden.

The Phase Gates & The 90-Day Cadence

PART XII · THE PLAYBOOK

PHASE-GATED TO THE PLATFORM'S OWN THRESHOLDS

P1

Foundation

Personal account, search-indexed handle and bio, three-pin trailer, CML audio SOP, reaction-critique format locked



P2

The climb

Content-Gap calendar, Smart Split podcast pipeline, the ritual day, reply-with-video loop → 10k / 100k



P3

The right hooks

Subscription on, Series salon, LIVE cultural salon, media kit for inbound

The 90-day operating cadence

01

The ritual.

One fixed appointment format a week – the Academy's "every Sunday" mechanic. For Marty Gras, the cultural-curation slot the audience learns to expect.

02

The batch.

One or two filming days. Talking points pre-mapped. A designated, always-ready space. Consistency over perfection – the platform's stated physics.

03

The mine.

One posting slot built entirely from comments – the reader-question column, in video. The audience co-authors the brand.

WHAT MARTY GRAS DOES NOT DO

- Cross-post letterboxed Reels – native-cut only, or it reads as foreign
- Chase a daily post count – the Academy says volume is not the lever
- Stuff hashtags – five, all genuinely descriptive; stuffing is spam-flagged
- Repackage without a take – unoriginal is unmonetisable by formula
- Go Business – it forfeits Creator Rewards

Verification needs earned press – bank media hits toward the blue check, 30-day reapply cooldown.

The platform decides reach by the content alone. For a brand whose entire premise is a point of view worth feeling, that is not a constraint. That is the most level playing field in media.

Appendix A

The Numbers Card

Every hard threshold the Academy states, on one spread. Carry these. They are the gates everything else is engineered toward.



FOUNDATION & CRAFT	VALUE
Time spent in the For You feed	96%
Bio character ceiling	160
Handle change frequency	30 days
Pinned video slots	3
The hook window	3-5 sec
Reach lift, video over 60s	+43%
Watch time, video over 2 min	+64%
High-quality watch-time premium	+72%
Watch on mute	30%+
Smart Split source allowance	150 min/mo
Hashtag ceiling	5
For You recommendation window	~90 days

MONEY & THRESHOLDS	VALUE
Creator Rewards followers	10,000
Creator Rewards views / 30d	100,000
Qualifying video length	> 1 min
Qualified-view watch minimum	5 sec
Search-view watch minimum	30 sec
Views before a video earns	1,000
Payout floor / day	\$50 · 15th
LIVE gifting revenue share	50%
Scaled LIVE Rewards ceiling	53%
Subscription price range	\$2.99-99.99
Subscription default · Super Fan	\$5.99 · \$9.99
Subscription revenue share	70 → 90%

Series & features. Series – up to 80 videos, 30 seconds to 20 minutes each, 10,000–follower gate with a sub-10k premium-content bypass, up to 72-hour review. Playlists and Series unlock at 10k; bulk scheduling and Smart Split at 1k; pre-post review at 150k. LIVE titles cap at 32 characters; up to 20 moderators; target 60–80 minutes. Photo Mode – up to 35 images. Stories – 24 hours.

Disputed figures, flagged honestly. The Creator Rewards payout floor is stated as \$50 in the Academy FAQ; some surfaces cite \$10 – region-dependent. A 1,000–follower TikTok LIVE gate is widely repeated but the surfaced Academy text gave only an age requirement. Diamond-to-cash ratios circulating online are not Academy-sourced. Treat all three as **UNVERIFIED**.

These are the gates. Every other page in this manual is the strategy for clearing them.

For You feed (FYF) – the algorithmic main feed; 96% of user time. Distribution, not the follow.

Prediction score – the combined probability of interaction the system assigns each video, then ranks by.

Qualified view – a unique For You view of 5+ seconds, 30+ for Search; the unit Creator Rewards pays on.

RPM – gross revenue per 1,000 qualified views; Standard Reward plus an Additional quality multiplier.

Creator Rewards Program – the flagship payout; the Creator Fund successor.

Creator Search Insights – the in-app search-demand tool; the Content Gap tab finds high-demand, low-supply topics.

Content Gap – searched topics with insufficient quality supply; a commissioning radar.

TikTok Studio – the creation, scheduling and analytics cockpit; web for management work.

Smart Split – AI long-form-to-shorts in TikTok Studio Web; 1k followers, 150 min/month.

Series – paywalled video collection; up to 80 videos; the native premium long-form home.

Subscription – recurring monthly membership; owned community, 70 to 90% share.

Super Fan – the LIVE upgrade of Subscription; \$9.99, instant Fan Club level 10.

Diamonds – the currency Gifts convert to; drives the LIVE Weekly Ranking.

Originality Policy – the rule that makes repurposed content For-You-ineligible and unmonetisable.

Branded Content toggle – the disclosure switch; resolves to Promotional content or Paid partnership.

TikTok One – the brand-partnership platform; the Creator Marketplace successor.

The vocabulary is the strategy. A creator who uses these terms precisely is already thinking the way the platform is built.

A note on voice

Parts I through XI deliberately use the platform's own words – “creator”, “content”, the programme names – because the manual is teaching TikTok's system on its own terms. Part XII shifts register into the Marty Gras lexicon: Cultural Facilitator, perspective, newsletter and episode. The shift is intentional. The doctrine is universal. The application is a brand.

Every territory was drawn from **tiktok.com/creator-academy** alone. No third-party SEO blogs, no news outlets, no other TikTok subdomains. The consolidated slug set the nine agents worked from:

Foundations & algorithm

/article/TikTok-Business-vs-Personal · /how-to-personalize-profile · /8-tips-for-becoming-a-successful-TikTok-creator · /Account-verification-101 · /tiktok-studio · /power-of-tiktok-studio-web · /tool-analytics-intro · /Creator-Search-Insights · /search-insights-content-gap · /guidelines-recommendation-system-intro · /decoding-tiktok-recommendation-system · /Getting-discovered-with-Search · /posting-cadence-best-practices-publishers

Craft & engagement

/elements-of-tiktok-video · /captivating-content-with-great-storytelling · /Filming-101 · /Filming-102 · /lighting-101 · /audio-101 · /editing-like-a-pro · /smart-split · /longer-video-content-strategy · /video-covers-thumbnails · /building-a-sustainable-posting-routine · /building-a-thriving-community · /get-more-followers · /Understanding-and-engaging-with-your-audience · /Create-unforgettable-reaction-content

Features

/Going-LIVE · /live-best-practices-publishers · /LIVE-Features · /LIVE-Studio-tools · /capture-with-tiktok-stories · /photo-posting · /eligibility · /tool-playlists-intro · /promote-question-faq · /making-your-videos-more-accessible

Monetisation & subscription

/monetization-offerings-overview · /creator-rewards-program · /eligibility · /apply · /monetization-creativity-program-video-eligible · /monetization-creativity-program-qualified-view · /RPM-understanding-the-four-key-factors · /Creator-Rewards-Program-New-RPM-Dashboard · /creator-rewards-program-faq-2 · /tiktok-originality-policy · /scaled-live-rewards · /monetization-creativity-program-rewards-calculate · /Subscription · /Setting-up-your-Subscription · /subscription-or-superfan · /live-super-fan · /Any-rules-for-subscriber-only-content

Commerce & integrity

/create-branded-content · /brand-tagging-and-spark-ads-authorization · /tiktok-one · /regulated-goods-on-tiktok · /community-guidelines-overview · /Originality-Policy · /integrity-authenticity-on-tiktok · /safety-tips · /guidelines-moderation-status-and-appeals · /video-not-recommended · /commercial-music-library · /unlimited-sound-library · /Mental-Health · /creator-spotlight-* (series)

METHOD & HONESTY

The Creator Academy is a JavaScript single-page application; direct page fetches return only a navigation shell. Substance was recovered through the search index, which serves the platform's own rendered content. Nine Opus agents, ~270 scoped queries combined. Items the Academy did not state outright are tagged **UNVERIFIED** throughout and never presented as fact.

Slugs resolve under <https://www.tiktok.com/creator-academy/article/{slug}> and the /en/ locale variant. Compiled by nine Opus-class research agents, reconciled by Alfred, May 2026. Source-exclusive: [tiktok.com/creator-academy](https://www.tiktok.com/creator-academy).

MARTY GRAS

The Architect of Vibe

The platform tells you exactly how it works. This manual read all of it, so the work can begin from knowledge rather than guesswork.